

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1993-07-04

To an individual bahá'í

1 dear bahá'í friend,
2 your letter to him dated 14 june 1993, and we have been instructed to send
3 the following response.

The reason that the term “the bahá'ís in the west” was left unchanged

4 in the letter of 9 june 1974 addressed to the National Spiritual Assembly
5 of the bahá'ís of iceland when it was circulated to all National Spiritual
6 Assemblies on 9 may 1993,164-1 is that it is a term the significance of which
7 is generally understood by the friends, while to elucidate it exactly would have raised
unnecessary complications in such a context.

8 As you are aware, many of the laws of the kitáb-i-Aqdas were applied in
9 iran and the neighboring lands of the middle east from very early days, and
10 others were progressively enforced by Shoghi effendi. he used to comment
11 to pilgrims that he was raising the pillar of the administration of the cause
12 in the west and the pillar of the laws in the east.

13 As the faith spread in europe and the western hemisphere, certain laws
14 were applied there also, but fewer than were already current in iran. The
15 faith continued to spread around the world, and the terms “east” and “west”
16 in this context acquired specialized meanings. while the “east” continued
17 164-1. See no. 154, p. 334.164.1

164 2

164 3

164.4163 7

165 1993–1996 • The Three Year Plan

166 5to designate iran, iraq and other countries of the older bahá'í communities
167 of the middle east, the term “west” came to include the rest of the world.

168 Thus, persian pilgrims in the time of Shoghi effendi would stay in the
169 “eastern” pilgrim house, while Australian and chinese pilgrims would stay
170 in the “ western” pilgrim house.
171 To pioneer for the faith and for many other reasons, believers from iran
172 began to move to other parts of the world. This mere change in residence
173 was no reason for them to cease to observe those laws of the Aqdas with which they
were familiar, but they had to learn not to impose them on the “western” bahá’ís. with
intermarriage between “eastern” and “western”
174 bahá’ís other variations arose, depending upon whether the children were
175 raised in a western or eastern family environment.
176 in light of this explanation the individual believers now residing in the
177 “west” must decide in light of their own situations which of the laws are binding
upon them. The letter to the National Assembly of iceland clearly
178 lists those laws which are currently not binding on the “western” friends.
179 The fact that they are not binding does not, of course, mean that the believ-
180 ers are forbidden to obey them if they wish to and circumstances permit.

bahá’ís from iran who have migrated to the west should already know

181 which laws are binding upon them, having learned this in their homeland. bahá’ís of
iranian or mixed descent living in the west, whose parents have
182 not familiarized them with the laws, should at least follow those laws which are
universally binding.
183 with loving bahá’í greetings,

Department of the secretariat

184 165

Laws Regarding Hair and Manner of Dress

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]